



Very cold 27/12 • Tomorrow: Very cold 22/6 B20

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, JANUARY 27, 2026 • \$4

President to revisit the topic of prices

As midterms approach, he has often derailed his own economic message

BY MATT VISER

President Donald Trump's attempts to show Americans he cares about their struggles with rising costs began in earnest last month, when he went to a casino in Pennsylvania to talk about affordability — but instead mocked Democrats who use the term and called it “a hoax.”

Next, he traveled to Detroit to tout his efforts to revive American manufacturing. But again, he called affordability “a fake word by Democrats.”

Then, last week on a trip to Davos, Switzerland, he unveiled a new domestic housing policy meant to help families struggling with rising costs. There, too, the president stepped on his own announcement by stoking a global crisis over his desire to wrest control of Greenland from NATO ally Denmark.

Again and again, Trump has tried to stay focused on domestic economic uncertainty, an issue that Republicans fear could hobble them in this year's midterm elections. Again and again, the president's attention has drifted elsewhere — and away from the concerns of his restive base. In the past month, he has ordered a strike on Venezuela, considered military action against Iran and threatened to use force to take Greenland. None of these actions have inspired broad support within his core “America First” constituency, which the GOP needs to hold Congress.

On Tuesday, Trump will give it another go. The planned afternoon speech in Des Moines — assuming winter weather doesn't upend the trip — will focus on energy and the economy. It is part of what White House officials say will be an uptick in domestic travel ahead of what even Trump has acknowledged could be a difficult election in November. The trip also comes amid growing concern and political pressure on

SEE AFFORDABILITY ON A7

After the storm



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Pedestrians walk in the vehicle lanes on the Taft Bridge along Connecticut Avenue in Northwest Washington on Monday. A winter storm in the region Sunday produced several inches of snow, along with an unusual amount of sleet. Freezing temperatures will make digging out on secondary roads a long process. **Coverage, B13**

Work remains on effort to make D.C. skies safer

BY LORI ARATANI, TARA COPP AND RACHEL WEINER

Nearly a year after 67 people were killed in a midair collision in the skies above the nation's capital, all but the most critical helicopter flights near Reagan National Airport have been banned. The route the Army Black Hawk flew on the night of the collision has been permanently closed. And rules now bar helicopters and commercial jets from occupying the same airspace in certain areas near the airport.

In the control tower — where staffing on the night of the crash was “not normal,” according to a government report — updated procedures require that separate controllers manage passenger jets and helicopter traffic. There is

technology in place to help controllers regulate the flow of aircraft to reduce last-minute conflicts. The Army is upgrading and installing advanced surveillance technology, known as ADS-B systems, throughout its Black Hawk fleet.

These and other changes have made the airspace safer, experts say. But the work to prevent a repeat of the deadly crash between the military helicopter and an American Airlines regional jet — the deadliest commercial aircraft accident in more than two decades — is far from complete.

“It is safer,” said Jeff Guzzetti, a former Federal Aviation Administration and National Transportation Safety Board investigator. “But the question should be: Is it

SEE AIRSPACE ON A2

Inhaling Delhi's air is as harmful as smoking

BY PRANSHU VERMA, SUPRIYA KUMAR AND KEVIN CROWE

NEW DELHI — Tens of millions of people in India's capital city are breathing in polluted air that is equivalent to smoking roughly nine cigarettes a day, or about half of a standard pack, according to a Washington Post analysis of 2½ months of government data.

Every winter, for months at a time, Delhi is blanketed by toxic smog, and this year has been no different. Though people try to limit the time they spend outside, children need to go to school, parents need to go to the office, and most days the roadways are still choked with motorcycles and scooters and rickshaws, navi-

gating through a sepia haze. Delivery drivers, bricklayers and others who spend their days outdoors are especially vulnerable.

To quantify the toxicity of the air and its impact on human health, The Post analyzed 75 days of Indian government pollution data — spanning Oct. 18 to Dec. 31 — from 40 air monitoring stations spread across the capital region. Each station collects hourly data on chemicals in the atmosphere, such as particulate matter 2.5 (PM 2.5) and particulate matter 10 (PM 10), which are known to cause lung and heart issues when inhaled in large amounts.

Reporters calculated the daily average of PM 2.5, the most

SEE POLLUTION ON A12

Trump shifts on Minn. violence

SOFTER TONE AFTER LATEST KILLING

Border czar sent to take charge in Minneapolis

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF AND NATALIE ALLISON

President Donald Trump on Monday softened his tone on immigration enforcement in the wake of another killing of an American citizen by federal officers — and amid growing calls for investigations — by expressing sorrow over the bloodshed and sending a new personal envoy to take charge in Minneapolis.

At the same time, the White House tried to pin the violence on Democratic-led jurisdictions that prohibit local cooperation with federal immigration authorities. The administration warned that the violence won't end until Democratic governors and mayors assist federal law enforcement in arresting, detaining and deporting undocumented immigrants.

“Nobody in the White House, including President Trump, wants to see people getting hurt or killed in America's streets,” White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said Monday. “It is President Trump's hope and wish and demand for the resistance and chaos to end today.”

She added, “The most peaceful way to carry out this vital public safety mission is for Republicans and Democrats to do it together, and for state and local law enforcement to work together with federal law enforcement.”

The White House's more measured response to the shooting death of Alex Pretti on Saturday when compared with that of Renée Good earlier in January appears to shift the tone of an aggressive enforcement policy of Trump's own making. The clearest

SEE MINNESOTA ON A5

Evidence: Body-camera footage is being preserved, DOJ says. **A4**

TikTok: Users allege platform stifled posts about shooting. **A5**

Israel confirms remains of last hostage returned from Gaza

Recovery of body could pave the way for next phase of U.S.-backed ceasefire agreement with Hamas

BY ABBIE CHEESEMAN, LIOR SOROKA, CLAIRE PARKER AND KAREN DEYOUNG

Israel recovered Monday the remains of the last hostage held in Gaza, police officer Rani Gvili, marking an end to a dark and painful chapter for Israelis that began when Hamas and allied militants attacked the country on Oct. 7, 2023.

The return of Gvili's body could open the way for the next phase of the U.S.-backed ceasefire agreement, which could entail initial reconstruction of Gaza, the disarming of Hamas and a further Israeli pullback in the enclave.

Gvili, 24, was killed after he rushed to the border area to help victims of the Hamas attacks, according to an account his sister gave to the forum representing hostage families. He was on sick leave at the time for a dislocated shoulder and, according to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, died while fighting Palestinian militants in Kibbutz Alumim.

SEE HOSTAGE ON A9



MOTI MILROD/REUTERS

Photos of Ran Gvili, whose body was returned Monday from Gaza, seen in Tel Aviv's Hostages Square.

Aldi bets on U.S. expansion as groceries stretch budgets

BY JACLYN PEISER

If you haven't noticed an Aldi pop up in your area, don't worry. It's probably coming.

As grocery bills eat up a greater share of Americans' wallets, the Germany-based chain — known for its no-frills stores stocked with low-priced house-brand products — isn't letting off the gas in its U.S. expansion. That's because the company knows Americans need the store now more than ever, said Chad Lusk, a managing director in Alvarez & Marsal's consumer and retail group, a global consulting firm.

“Aldi's business model is basically engineered for this moment in time,” he said.

Grocery prices have surged 30 percent since the start of the pandemic, outpacing overall inflation's increase of about 26 percent, according to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. And it's not slowing down: The cost of food in December increased 0.7 percent month-over-month and about 2.4 percent year-over-year.

Facing these pressures, consumers are more willing to trade down for dupes or private-label brands. Spending data and executives' comments on earnings calls indicate that more Americans are prioritizing price and value in lieu of national brand loyalty. During the first 10 months of 2025, unit sales of store brands increased 0.3 percent while national brands fell 0.7 percent, according to the Private Label Manufacturers Association.

“Everyone's under pressure, so we've seen a lot of channel shift over the last number of years where customers are reporting leaving traditional grocery for nontraditional,” said John Clear, a partner in the retail practice at consulting firm AlixPartners. “There is a whole cohort of categories where the national brand incumbent doesn't really have a very strong value proposition. ... And they are really ripe for people like Aldi and Lidl and Costco to take them.”

Aldi, which is celebrating its

SEE ALDI ON A15

IN THE NEWS

Middle East A U.S. aircraft carrier has reached the region, bolstering options as President Donald Trump and his advisers weigh potential military strikes on Iran. **A12**

Teacher retention Both GOP and Democratic state lawmakers are looking to new paid leave policies to address educator shortages. **A3**

THE NATION

The deportation of a suspect in a jewelry heist left victims “in disbelief,” a lawyer said. **A3**
Dangerous and record-breaking cold could last for days, complicating storm recovery. **A6**

THE WORLD

Iraq's spy chief is warning of a renewed threat from the Islamic State as its ranks swell. **A8**
Germany is finding a breakup with the United States hard, given their 80-year bond. **A10**

THE ECONOMY

Lawsuits alleging that social media companies have fueled the teen mental health crisis are heading to trial. **A14**
Gold and silver prices surged, reflecting a broader shift away from dollar-based assets as a hedge against uncertainty. **A15**

STYLE

Blaire White, a trans, pro-MAGA YouTuber, has become a polarizing figure in both conservative and LGBT spaces. **B1**

SPORTS

In this season of change in the NFL, the Super Bowl brings a throwback matchup that features the best of the 2010s. **B7**

THE REGION

St. Elizabeths, the D.C. psychiatric hospital, has safety issues, staffers and patient advocates say. **B13**
A Maryland bill would allow domestic violence survivors who are convicted of crimes to present evidence of abuse as a mitigating factor in sentencing. **B13**

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54474

